



The Anatomy of a Test Case

Building Blocks of Repeatable Testing

MODULE 4 · SKILL-WANDERER DOJO · MANUAL SOFTWARE TESTING

The Testing Ecosystem



Test Scenario

Definition

High-level idea of what to verify.

Example

Check the booking form validation.



Test Case

Definition

Step-by-step, repeatable execution plan.

Example

Steps, data, and expected result for one specific validation rule.



Bug Report

Definition

Evidence that a test case failed.

Example

Submitting with an empty date field allows checkout.

The 12 Building Blocks

Identity Group

01. ID

Unique sortable identifier.

02. Title

Precise, single-sentence summary.

03. Module

Area of application under test.

04. Traceability

Link to requirement or user story.

Setup & Execution Group

05. Environment

Browser, OS, device, and build.

06. Preconditions

Required system state before execution.

07. Test Data

Exact inputs used for the test.

08. Test Steps

Numbered, atomic actions to perform.

Outcome Group

09. Expected Result

What should happen (written beforehand).

10. Actual Result

Objective, observed outcome.

11. Status

Derived Pass/Fail verdict.

12. Priority/Severity

Urgency and technical impact metrics.

The Setup: Preconditions & Test Data



Preconditions

The Contract: Preconditions are not optional. They dictate the exact state the system must be in before Step 1.

Example: Account has zero items in cart. Without this, identical steps produce different results.



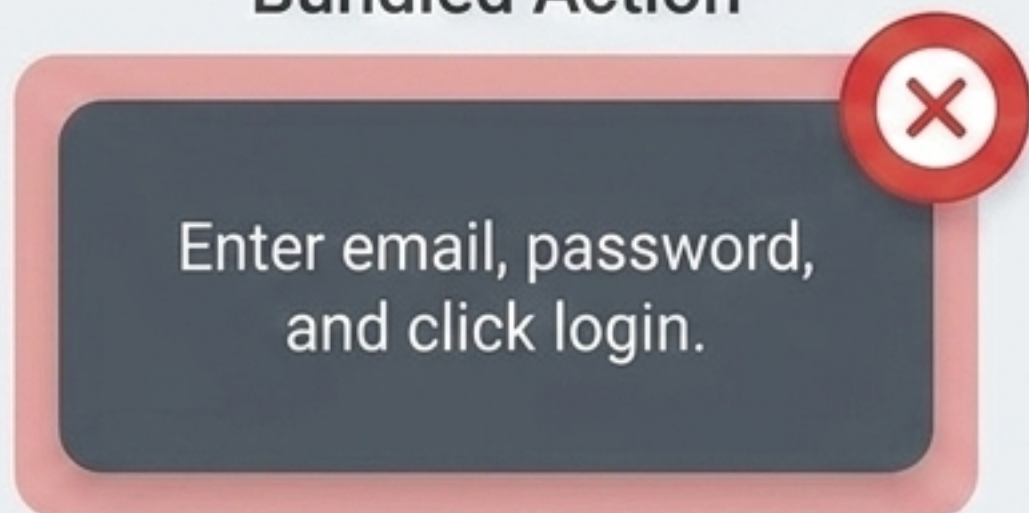
Test Data

The Decoupling: Keep exact inputs separate from the execution steps.

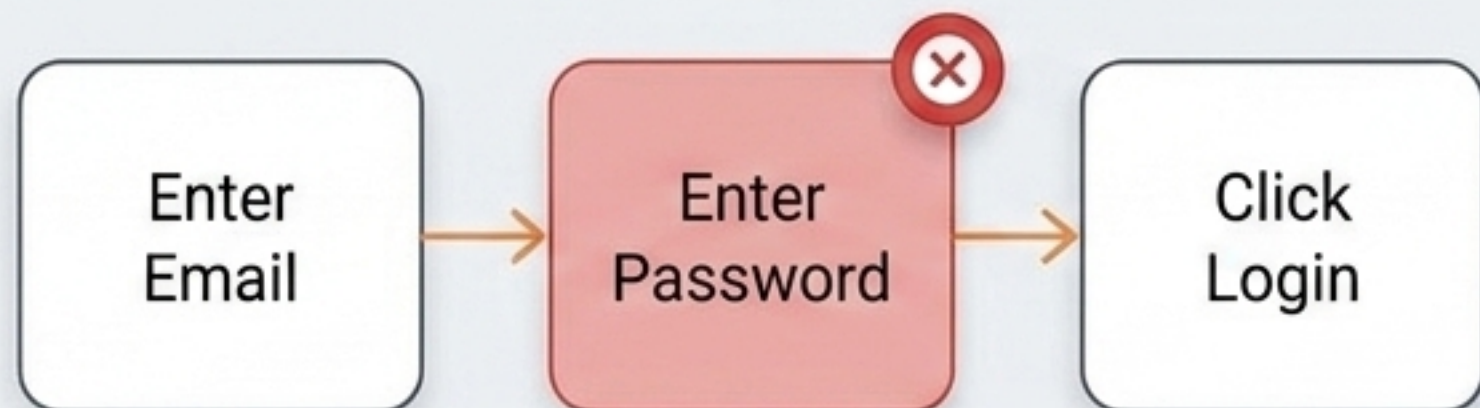
Why: Allows the identical test steps to be re-run cleanly with entirely different data sets in the future.

Writing Atomic Steps

Bundled Action



Atomic Actions



Rules for Writing Atomic Steps

- 1. One Action Per Step.** Never bundle actions. Bundled steps hide exactly which action broke the system.
- 2. Present-Tense Imperative.** Use direct commands (Enter, Select, Scroll). Never past tense.
- 3. Platform Specificity.** Use Tap for mobile, Click for desktop. Never mix them.
- 4. Actions, Not Outcomes.** Never use Observe as a step action. Observation is the outcome, not the trigger.

Outcomes: Expected vs. Actual



Expected Result

- Written before execution.
- Must be highly observable and specific.
- Bad: It should work.
- Good: User redirected to /dashboard; welcome toast displays within 2 seconds.



Actual Result

- Recorded during/after execution.
- The objective, observed outcome.
- Must be recorded objectively even when it perfectly matches expectations (e.g., As expected; error shown, no redirect).

Triage: Priority vs. Severity



Priority

The Business Decision

What it means:

Fix urgency and testing order.

Who sets it:

Product Owners or Team Leads.



Severity

The Technical Impact

What it means:

How badly the system is broken (e.g., UX bug vs. Security flaw).

Who sets it:

QA/Tester, based directly on observation.

Anatomy in Action

TC-AUTH-002

Module: Authentication

Status: PASS

Priority: HIGH

Verify user cannot log in with correct email and incorrect password

Preconditions

- 1) Active account exists.
- 2) User is logged out on Login page.

Test Data

Email: qauser@demo.com | Password: WrongPass99!

Test Steps

1. Enter valid email.
2. Enter incorrect password.
3. Click Log In button.

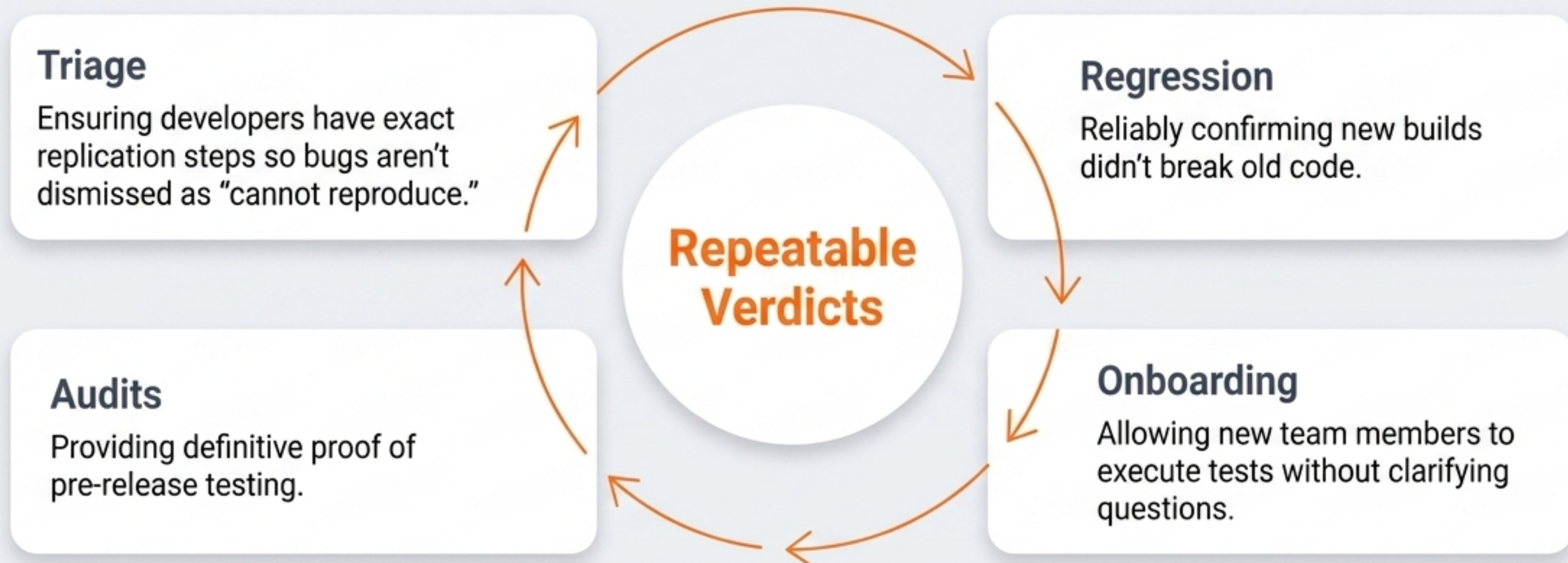
Expected Result

Login rejected. Inline error 'Incorrect email or password' below form. No session token.

Environment: Windows 11, Chrome (latest), Build 2.4.1

The Engine of Repeatability

Core Insight: A test case is only valuable if running it twice, by two different people on two different days, produces the exact same verdict.



Common Pitfalls & Corrections



Write expected results after seeing actual behavior (causes quiet bias).



Lock in observable expectations before running Step 1.



Merge multiple root-cause issues into one test case.



Report the first occurrence and note duplicates separately.



Skip the test environment field.



Specify OS, Browser, and Build to prevent "failed on my machine" dismissals.

The Professional QA Mindset

1 Beyond Personal Notes

A test case is not a subjective to-do list; it is an objective, repeatable execution plan.

2 Built on Evidence

The 12 building blocks exist to protect testing from ambiguity, assumptions, and untraceable failures.

3 The Ultimate Contract

A well-crafted test case guarantees that the same conditions will produce the same verdict—securing your credibility as a QA professional.